

CST-407 Activity 9 Technology Security in a Christian Organization

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Up-to-Date and Best Practices (Good)

Backups - GCF has a backup process that ensures critical data such as donations and membership information is preserved. This aligns with best practices for disaster recovery and demonstrates good stewardship of sensitive information.

Encryption - Donation platforms like Pushpay and financial tools like Aplos employ encryption for data in transit and at rest. This protects financial and personal data from interception or unauthorized access.

Multi-Factor Authentication - MFA has been enabled for staff logins on critical systems, reducing the risk of unauthorized access and following modern zero-trust security principles.

SSL Certificates - GCF's main websites and donation portals use SSL certificates, ensuring secure communications and protecting user trust during online giving.

Vendor Security Reviews - The church partners with reputable third-party vendors (BoxCast, Pushpay, Aplos) that are compliant with standards like PCI DSS and GDPR, reflecting diligence in vendor selection.

Acceptable Practices but Could Use Improvement (Adequate)

Content Management Policy - The church uses multiple software platforms (Breeze, Flocknote, BoxCast), but there is no unified content management policy. While these tools function well individually, the lack of consistent governance can lead to duplicated efforts or overlooked updates. Recommendation: establish a formal content management policy that defines ownership, update cycles, and retention rules.

Disaster Response Plans - GCF has some ad hoc recovery processes but lacks a fully documented and tested disaster response plan. Without rehearsals, staff may be unprepared during a crisis. Recommendation: create a formal disaster recovery plan and schedule regular drills.

Monitoring and Logging - Logs are available within vendor tools (Pushpay for donations, BoxCast for streaming), but they are not aggregated or actively monitored. This limits the ability to detect suspicious behavior quickly. Recommendation: adopt centralized monitoring and alerting for critical systems.

User Account Review - Accounts for staff and volunteers exist across multiple systems, but reviews of access rights are inconsistent. Recommendation: perform quarterly user access audits and ensure timely removal of former staff or volunteers.

Practice of Informing Users of How Their Data Is Used - While GCF values trust and has policies in place, communication to members about how their data is collected and used could be clearer. Recommendation: implement a transparent privacy notice and routine updates to the congregation.

High-Risk Practices with Potential for Serious Consequences (Urgent)

Password Policies - Current password practices are weak and lack enforcement of complexity, expiration, or reuse restrictions. This creates a significant risk of account compromise.

Recommendation: Implement a strong password policy (length, complexity, expiration), combined with MFA to minimize risk.

Software Updates - Some legacy systems in use at GCF no longer receive vendor security patches. This exposes the church to preventable exploits. Recommendation: Phase out unsupported systems and establish a documented patch management schedule to ensure all software remains up-to-date.

Tools Not Well-Aligned with GCF's Mission - Certain tools add unnecessary complexity, leading to inefficiencies and confusion among staff. Complexity increases error rates and hinders adoption, which in turn can create security gaps. Recommendation: streamline technology to tools that are mission-critical, consolidating where possible.

Items Evaluated

- Backups
- Content Management Policy
- Disaster Response Plans
- Encryption
- Monitoring and Logging
- Multi-Factor Authentication
- Password Policies
- Software Updates
- SSL Certificates
- User Account Review
- Vendor Security Reviews
- Practice of Informing Users of How Their Data Is Used
- Tools Not Well-Aligned with GCF's Mission

How IT Supports GCF's Mission

Information technology at Grace Community Fellowship directly supports the mission of loving God, serving people, and making disciples. Tools like Breeze ChMS streamline member care, Pushpay ensures safe and reliable digital donations, and BoxCast allows worship services to reach members who cannot attend in person. These systems reduce administrative burdens so staff and volunteers can focus more on ministry. Security measures such as encryption, SSL certificates, and multi-factor authentication help maintain the congregation's trust, which is essential for sustaining financial support and fostering open communication. By leveraging technology responsibly, GCF enhances both the spiritual and operational aspects of its mission.

Recommendations Summary

Maintain strong practices: Continue regular backups, use of encryption, multi-factor authentication, SSL certificates, and periodic vendor reviews.

Improve adequate areas: Develop a formal content management policy, create and test a disaster recovery plan, implement centralized monitoring/logging, schedule quarterly user access audits, and publish a clear data privacy notice for members.

Address urgent risks immediately: Enforce stronger password policies, replace or patch legacy systems, and simplify tools to those aligned with GCF's mission to reduce security gaps and staff confusion.

Mission alignment: Ensure that every IT tool chosen directly supports ministry goals of communication, discipleship, and community engagement.

Summary of Key Points

Grace Community Fellowship has made important strides in using technology to support its mission of loving God, serving people, and making disciples. Several practices, such as backups, encryption, multi-factor authentication, SSL certificates, and vendor reviews, reflect strong alignment with security best practices. At the same time, areas like content management, disaster recovery planning, monitoring, account reviews, and transparency around data use are only partially effective and would benefit from clearer policies and consistent implementation. More concerning are urgent risks such as weak password policies, reliance on outdated systems, and the use of tools that add unnecessary complexity. Addressing these risks will be critical to protecting the congregation's trust, financial stability, and overall ministry effectiveness. By maintaining its strengths, improving adequate practices, and resolving urgent vulnerabilities, GCF can ensure that its technology infrastructure remains both secure and mission-focused for years to come.